

Younghee Son

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Department of Economics
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Fields

Health Economics, Labor Economics

Education

2022 – 2027 (Expected)	Ph.D., Economics, Michigan State University <i>Committee:</i> Todd Elder (Chair), Stacy Dickert-Conlin, Hanzhe Zhang
2022 – 2024	M.A., Economics, Michigan State University
2010 – 2016	B.A., Economics, Korea University

Job Market Paper

“Organ Availability and Transplant Candidate Behavior”

Liver transplant candidates decline more than half of the organs offered to them, even though no alternative treatment exists. Each year, roughly one in eight dies or becomes too sick for transplant while waiting. This paper studies how candidates make these decisions. The 2020 Acuity Circles reform changed how candidates are prioritized, redrawing both the geographic boundaries and redefining the medical urgency groups. Using offer-level data from the Scientific Registry of Transplant Recipients, I show that candidates who gained access became more selective: a one-standard-deviation increase in expected offer arrival rates lowers the probability of accepting an offer by 4.7 percentage points, a 12.6 percent decline. To interpret this behavior, I estimate a dynamic discrete choice model of the accept-or-wait decision. Candidates weigh the offer at hand against the chance of a better offer later, knowing they may die or become too sick while waiting. The estimated model implies that the reform raised average welfare at listing by an amount equivalent to roughly doubling donor supply, with only 1.6 percent of candidates made worse off. I then evaluate several counterfactual policy changes, including a widely debated one which would replace the remaining boundaries with a continuous score that incorporates both medical urgency and proximity. I find that prioritizing the sickest candidates raises average welfare but at the cost of wasted organs.

Work in Progress

“The Intergenerational Transmission of Task Content and Skills”

“Regulation-Induced Mergers: Incentives and Outcomes in Organ Procurement”

Research and Professional Experience

2024 – Present	Research Assistant to Professor Todd Elder, Michigan State University
2016 – 2022	Junior Economist, Bank of Korea

Presentations

2026	Missouri Valley Economic Association Annual Meeting (scheduled); MSU Grand River Conference; MSU Applied Microeconomics Seminar; MSU Economics Graduate Student Seminar
2025	Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting; MSU Red Cedar Conference; MSU Economics Graduate Student Seminar

Fellowships, Awards, and Honors

2026	Summer Research Fellowship, Department of Economics, Michigan State University
2025	Red Cedar Award (best third-year paper), Department of Economics, Michigan State University
2023	Peter Schmidt Award, Honorable Mention (best first-year Ph.D. student), Department of Economics, Michigan State University

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant, Michigan State University

Fall 2026	Advanced Econometrics I (Graduate); Analysis of Labor Markets
Spring 2026	Advanced Data Analysis in Economics
Fall 2025	Econometrics IA (Graduate)
Fall 2024	Analysis of Labor Markets
Spring 2024	Microeconomics II (Graduate)
Fall 2023	Introduction to Econometric Methods
Spring 2023	Macroeconomics and Public Policy
Fall 2022	Introduction to Macroeconomics

Service

2024 – 2025	Board Member, Economics Graduate Student Organization, Michigan State University
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Skills

Programming & Software: Stata, R, Python, MATLAB

Methods: Causal inference, Structural modeling, Supervised/unsupervised machine learning, NLP

Data: Exploratory Data Analysis and Visualization

Languages: Korean (native), English (fluent)

References

Todd Elder (Chair)
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Stacy Dickert-Conlin
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